

Unique Preservation of the Qur'an

- The Qur'an stands apart from other scriptures due to its **dual preservation**:
 1. **Oral Transmission** – From the Prophet's companions to successive generations, millions have memorized the Qur'an (*huffaz*), ensuring an unbroken chain of recitation.
 2. **Written Record** – Standardized under Caliph Uthman within two decades of the Prophet's passing, distributed across the Muslim world, and verified by existing manuscripts.

Famous Surviving Early Manuscripts of the Qur'an

1. Topkapi Manuscript (Istanbul, Turkey)

- Preserved in the **Topkapi Palace Museum** in Istanbul.
- Traditionally attributed to one of the *Uthmanic codices*, standardized during the caliphate of Uthman ibn Affan (r. 644–656 CE).
- Written in early **Kufic script**, characterized by angular letters and minimal diacritical marks.
- Considered one of the most complete and carefully preserved Qur'anic manuscripts from the early Islamic centuries.

2. Samarkand Manuscript (Tashkent, Uzbekistan)

- Housed in the **Hast-Imam Library** in Tashkent.
- Traditionally believed to have belonged to Caliph Uthman and brought to Central Asia in the early Islamic conquests.
- Famous for its very large parchment leaves written in Kufic script.
- Though **incomplete**, it remains one of the most celebrated Qur'anic manuscripts and a symbol of early Islamic heritage.

3. Birmingham Qur'an Manuscript (United Kingdom)

- Preserved at the **University of Birmingham's Cadbury Research Library**.

- Radiocarbon analysis dates the parchment to **568–645 CE**, overlapping with the Prophet Muhammad’s lifetime (570–632 CE).
- Written in **Hijazi script**, one of the earliest Arabic scripts with slanted letters and simple ornamentation.
- Its dating makes it among the **earliest known Qur’anic fragments**, confirming the Qur’an’s preservation from its earliest period.

4. Sana’a Manuscript (Yemen)

- Discovered in **1972** in the Great Mosque of Sana’a during restoration works.
- Includes a **palimpsest**, meaning an earlier text was erased and overwritten, yet both layers have been studied by scholars.
- The upper text matches the standardized Uthmanic Qur’an, while the lower text shows minor orthographic variations without affecting meaning.
- This discovery highlights the **remarkable textual consistency** of the Qur’an across centuries.

5. Mushaf al-Madina and Other Early Fragments

- Numerous early fragments are preserved worldwide, including in the:
 - **Bibliothèque Nationale de France (Paris)**
 - **British Library (London)**
 - **Dar al-Makhtutat (Sana’a, Yemen)**
- These manuscripts, written in early Kufic and Hijazi scripts, testify to the **rapid and widespread transmission** of the Qur’an in the first century of Islam.